FUGUE VII

THIS Fugue is (like the great E major in Book II.) the purest vocal writing and, but for the extreme height of the soprano entry in bars 38-43 and a couple of extreme bass notes, could easily be sung by a chorus. This conception is the main key to its interpretation. The most difficult passage is that for the left hand in bars 40-43, where it is all-important that the tenor should be heard to hold its suspensions. Accordingly, the bass should here have its crotchets lightly detached (it will be heard quite well without great tone), while the tenor should sing out in a strict *legato*, so that its absence may be distinctly noticed in bar 44. Then the bass will emerge into leadership. Another difficulty, very rare in Bach (especially in so easy a piece) is the stretch in bar 22, which was far more risky on his instruments than on ours. Here the tied note should be repeated, even by hands large enough not only to stretch the ninth, but to approach it without squirming; and, of course, pedal must be used.

The Subject is the only theme in the composition. During the Exposition (bars 1-30) Bach does not trouble to vary the very modest counterpoint which accompanies the Answer; but this does not make it a Countersubject to be characterised. At bar 30 the special design of the Fugue appears in a Stretto between tenor and bass. In bar 37 the other two parts follow with its converse (the alto leading and the treble answering in the upper fourth).

At bar 44 begins the only Episode, a broad dialogue on bar 3 in the treble and alto, over a distant bass which answers their new connecting figure. Do not on any account force the tone, or the passage will sound thin and hard. It should drift indolently towards subdominant regions till in bar 53 the tenor awakens, and, carrying the Subject grandly into the actual key of the subdominant, leads to the final statement of the Stretto between treble and bass (bars 59-65). This is easily made to ring out, and the player can afford also to attend to the superb rhetoric of the tenor from bar 60 onwards. In bar 65 the D♭ and the answer of the sustained treble by the inner parts with rests are culminating rhetorical points; likewise, of course, the last word of the tenor in bars 68-70.

The *tempo* is a very moderate two, in which only the absence of a second accent prevents us from counting four in the bar.

Donald Francis Tovey: The Well-Tempered Clavier, Book II
Associated Board, 1924. Printed pp. 43.
BWV 876. Complete original pages; adjoining commentary is retained.
Full source scan